a bit clearer

PYTHON AND AI · EPISODE 02

What Is Python?

Getting Started

KEY POINTS

- Python was created by **Guido van Rossum** and first released in **February 1991**.
- It's named after **Monty Python's Flying Circus**, not the snake.
- A programming language is a **precise** language that both humans and computers understand.
- Python took **#1 on the TIOBE index in October 2021** and still holds it (20.86%, November 2026).

01 Meet Python

▶ VIDEO 00:00

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
Christmas 1989	Guido van Rossum, a programmer from the Netherlands, starts Python as a hobby project.
Feb 1991	He shares it with the world.
Until Jul 2018	He leads the language, with the title **Benevolent Dictator For Life**.
Today	An elected **steering council** of five guides Python.

> KEY IDEA
>
> Python's big promise: code that's **simple to read** and **easy to start with**.

02 Why the Name

▶ VIDEO 00:55

Guido was reading scripts from **Monty Python's Flying Circus**, a British comedy show from the 1970s, and wanted a name that was short, unique, and slightly mysterious. But the snake stuck: today's logo is two snakes, wrapped around each other.

03 What Is a Programming Language

▶ VIDEO 01:21

Human language is full of **ambiguity**. Ask for "a carton of milk, and if they have eggs, get six", and a literal listener comes back with six cartons of milk. A computer needs a language with **strict structure and precise logic**: a programming language. Here's the shopping trip in Python. You don't need to understand it yet, but you can almost read it:

shopping.py PYTHON

```python
# Episode 02 · The shopping joke, written so a computer can't get it wrong.
store = ["milk", "eggs", "bread"]

print("Buy 1 carton of milk")
if "eggs" in store:
    print("Buy 6 eggs")
```

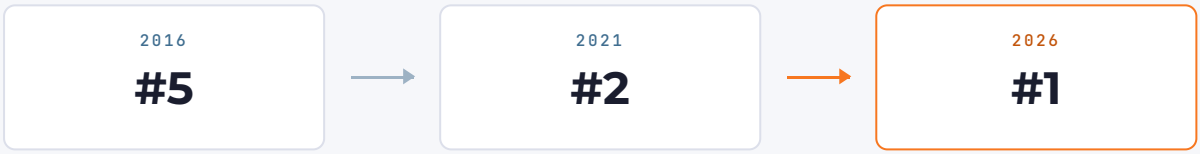
Output

```
Buy 1 carton of milk
Buy 6 eggs
```

04 Number One

▶ VIDEO 02:45

FIGURE 2.1 **TIOBE index: Python's average rank**



C and Java held the top spot for twenty years. In October 2021, Python took first place for the first time ever. In November 2026 it's still #1, at 20.86%. It has been Language of the Year six times (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024), more than any other language.

05 Why So Popular

▶ VIDEO 03:19

- **Reach:** office automation, web scraping, web apps, data analysis, testing, servers and infrastructure, and lots of beginners.
- **AI:** machine learning, deep learning, neural networks, and apps built on large language models. According to GitHub, Python powers **nearly half of all new AI repositories**.

> **Python isn't popular just because it's easy. It's popular because it's easy, and it's everywhere.**

CODE 1 file on GitHub github.com/abitclearer/python-and-ai/tree/main/02-what-is-python